

Communique

The Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) met for the fourth time on 1 March 2023.

Members noted the progress achieved to date in attracting, retaining and protecting workers in the agriculture and processing industries, including:

- securing 13,200 fee-free TAFE places for agriculture across the country;
- seeing 17,700 PALM workers arrive in Australia since June 2022, reaching the government's target of 35,000 workers, six months ahead of time;
- having over 115,000 working holiday makers arrive in Australia since borders reopened,
- extending post study work rights for international students;
- passing of legislation that allows pensioners to earn \$4000 more per year without affecting their pension; and
- the expansion of the Australian Apprenticeship Priority List to include more agriculture, processing and veterinary careers.

Members discussed the need to build on these early achievements through enduring solutions to workforce challenges in agriculture and processing sectors and the importance of attracting Australians by promoting well-paid, secure, local employment and careers.

Members also agreed to progress further work on promoting the experience of working in agriculture and processing and attracting skilled graduates into the sector.

Members endorsed a submission to Skills Ministers and the new Agribusiness Jobs and Skills Council advocating for enhanced training options and opportunities for current and prospective workers in agriculture, including through:

- the establishment of an agricultural trade apprenticeship; and
- the adoption of flexible industry-led training models such as AgSkilled 2.0.

Members acknowledged the importance of workplace safety and agreed to further work to investigate the merit of developing an Agricultural White Card.

Members discussed the need for robust evidence on the skills in demand in agriculture and processing sectors and endorsed advocacy for a Food Supply Chain Workforce Capacity Study.

Members support a national labour hire licensing scheme. However, members commissioned further work on developing joint labour hire licensing principles for consideration of the Government in designing a national scheme, implementation of which would fulfil one of the recommendations of the Migrant Workers' Taskforce.

Members also noted the update on action items being progressed through sub-groups focused on migration and worker protection.

The Working Group will next meet in April 2023.

Attendees

- Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Scott Connolly, Assistant Secretary, Australian Council of Trade Unions
- Ann Gardiner, National Council member, Australian Dairy Farmers
- Shane Roulstone, National Organising Director, Australian Workers' Union
- Jannette Armstrong, Executive Director - Farms, United Workers Union
- Patrick Hutchinson, CEO, Australian Meat Industry Council
- Matt Journeaux, Federal Secretary, Australasian Meat Industry Employees Union
- Emma Germano, President, Victorian Farmers' Federation
- Ben Rogers, General Manager, Workplace Relations & Legal Affairs, National Farmers Federation
- Andrew Metcalfe AO, Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- James Flintoft, Independent Facilitator
- John Azarias, Special Advisor to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on Agricultural Workforce Issues

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